

Checklist:

Organizational Design

1. Choose the right lever

- ☐ Is this a quick, cheap problem? Use **process design**.
- ☐ Is this a long-term problem that will take time to solve well? Evolve **culture**.
- ☐ Are process and culture both relevant? Use **organizational design** to bridge them.

2. Size teams deliberately

Manager load

- ☐ Each engineering manager supports roughly **6–8 engineers**.
- ☐ Managers with fewer than 4 engineers are not stuck as accidental tech leads.
- ☐ Managers with more than 8–9 engineers are not merely acting as coaches/firefighters.
- ☐ Managers-of-managers support roughly **4–6 managers**.
- ☐ Managers-of-managers with fewer than 4 managers are in an active ramping/transition phase, not a permanent state.

Team size

- ☐ Each team is large enough to operate independently.
- ☐ On-call teams have around **8 engineers** for a sustainable 24/7 rotation.
- ☐ Teams with fewer than 4 people are treated as temporary exceptions.
- ☐ Empty teams are not created.
- ☐ New teams are created by growing an existing team to 8–10 people, then splitting into two teams of 4–5.
- ☐ Managers are not left supporting more than 8 individuals for long periods.

3. Diagnose each team's state

For each team, mark its current state:

- ☐ **Falling behind:** backlog grows every week.
- ☐ **Treading water:** critical work gets done, but no debt repayment or major new work starts.
- ☐ **Repaying debt:** technical debt is being reduced, and compounding benefits are beginning.
- ☐ **Innovating:** debt is low, morale is high, and most work satisfies new user needs.

4. Apply the right system fix

If the team is falling behind

- ☐ Add people until the team can tread water.
- ☐ Avoid stealing people from other fragile teams.
- ☐ Set expectations with users and stakeholders.
- ☐ Celebrate easy wins and maintain optimism.

If the team is treading water

- ☐ Reduce work in progress.
- ☐ Consolidate effort so more work gets finished.
- ☐ Limit concurrent projects.
- ☐ Help individuals shift from personal productivity to team-level throughput.

If the team is repaying debt

- ☐ Add time, not necessarily people.
- ☐ Protect space for debt repayment.
- ☐ Keep users and stakeholders informed so debt work remains visible.
- ☐ Prevent the team from slipping back into backlog growth.

If the team is innovating

- ☐ Maintain slack.
- ☐ Avoid overloading the team just because it appears healthy.
- ☐ Ensure innovation work is valued by stakeholders.
- ☐ Preserve quality, learning, and long-term adaptability.

5. Consolidate investment

- ☐ Prioritize one constrained team at a time.
- ☐ Do not spread limited resources thinly across many teams.
- ☐ Staff one team until it reaches the next healthier state, then move to another.
- ☐ Allow teams to alternate between growth periods and consolidation periods.
- ☐ Avoid disrupting a team's gelling process with constant staffing changes.

6. Avoid harmful global optimization

- ☐ Do not casually move people out of high-performing teams.
- ☐ Treat high-performing teams as scarce and valuable.
- ☐ Account for re-gelling costs when moving people.
- ☐ Avoid moving teams below the size needed for on-call or core responsibilities.
- ☐ Preserve slack in teams that have earned it.
- ☐ Prefer shifting scope to teams over moving people between teams.
- ☐ Use temporary rotations when help is needed elsewhere.

7. Manage hypergrowth carefully

Hiring and training

- ☐ Check whether hiring is slowing down the existing team.
- ☐ Track how much time trained engineers spend interviewing.
- ☐ Track how much time trained engineers spend onboarding new hires.
- ☐ Give interviewers periodic breaks when they exceed about three interviews per week.
- ☐ Avoid growing faster than training systems can absorb.

Organizational scaling

- ☐ Add a new management layer for each additional order of magnitude of engineers.
- ☐ Add teams for roughly every 8-10 engineers.
- ☐ Watch for increased load on deployment tools, incident response, planning, and coordination.
- ☐ Recognize that systems often survive only one order of magnitude of growth without redesign.

Entropy control

- ☐ Ensure some projects finish.
- ☐ Concentrate on hiring and growth rather than spreading it evenly across the board.
- ☐ Funnel interruptions into a smaller area.
- ☐ Automate repetitive interruptions.
- ☐ Create useful documentation and documentation search.
- ☐ Build ownership registries so people know who owns what.
- ☐ Avoid unnecessary rewrites.
- ☐ Keep interfaces stable during system rewrites.
- ☐ Treat gatekeeping as an implementation bug, not a stability feature.

8. Manage organizational risk

- ☐ Identify sources of organizational debt.
- ☐ Track risks such as toxic culture, painful processes, struggling leaders, or inequitable mechanisms.
- ☐ Pick a few areas to improve deliberately.
- ☐ Agree with your manager on what constitutes reasonable progress.
- ☐ Give yourself permission to handle some lower-priority risks poorly.
- ☐ Stabilize one team or area before moving focus elsewhere.
- ☐ Delegate only risks that are realistically solvable.
- ☐ Keep ownership of risks that are unlikely to go well.

9. Build succession plans

Identify what you do

- ☐ Review your calendar and list your recurring meeting roles.
- ☐ List your calendar roles outside meetings, such as planning or candidate closing.
- ☐ Review the past six months of recurring processes.
- ☐ Document your role in each recurring process.
- ☐ List where your reports depend on your skills, authorization, advice, or organizational knowledge.
- ☐ Audit inbound chats and emails for recurring requests.
- ☐ Review your to-do list for work you keep postponing.
- ☐ Identify external relationships important to your role.

Close the gaps

- ☐ Identify people who could already take over each responsibility.
- ☐ Cross off responsibilities that already have a clear owner.
- ☐ For remaining items, identify people who could eventually take them over.
- ☐ Separate easy gaps from risky gaps.
- ☐ Close easy gaps first with documentation or a quick handoff.
- ☐ Choose one or two risky gaps to actively reduce.
- ☐ Add the plan to your personal goals.
- ☐ Repeat the succession exercise at least once a year.